

Starting Your Dream Project

A short guide for young founders who want land, community, and meaningful work — and don't yet know in what order to do it.

Why this guide exists

Most young people with a vision for an eco-project, intentional community, or land-based school make the same mistake: they look for land first. Land is emotional, visible, and feels like progress. But every successful community of the last sixty years — Findhorn, Tamera, Sieben Linden, The Farm, Crystal Waters, Lakabe — did it in a different order. They found **people** first, built a **form** second, and only then bought **land**.

This guide walks through that order. It is short on purpose. Read it once, then we can talk through it together.

The core reframe

You don't have 20,000 €. You have a seed. Alone, it buys nothing useful. Pooled with seven other committed people, it becomes 160,000 € — which in interior Portugal, Spain, or southern Italy can buy a small farm with buildings.

So the real question is not *where is my land* but *who are my seven people*, and *what vessel will hold us together when things get hard*.

The sequence that works

1. Write the vision down.

One page. What you are building, what you are not, what level of commitment is required. Specific enough to exclude people. A vague manifesto attracts everyone and commits no one; a specific one attracts three people, and those three are the project.

2. Put yourself in front of aligned people before asking them to join you.

Teach a short course. Write publicly. Host an event. Run a weekend. Every founder of a successful community already had a public practice that drew in the people who eventually became co-founders. They didn't invent an audience — they converted one.

3. Send a narrow call, not a broad one.

Not "who wants to live on a farm?" but "here is the vision, here is the commitment, come to a weekend and let's see if we fit." The weekend is the filter. Expect most people not to come back. That is the system working.

4. Live together temporarily, before land.

Rented house, seasonal work camp, co-housing for a year. This is where most groups die, and it is supposed to be. You are finding out whether you can cook, clean, fight, and decide together. Skipping this phase is the single most reliable way to blow up later.

5. Choose a legal form before buying land.

In Portugal this is usually an *associação*, a *cooperativa*, or in some cases a *fundação*. The form separates the project from any one person, protects it if someone leaves, and makes fundraising possible. It is boring. It is also the most important decision you will make.

6. The legal entity buys the land. Not a person.

Marginal rural land in interior Portugal still trades at 1,500–5,000 € per hectare. Old stone ruins and abandoned quintas come up regularly. A group of 8 with pooled capital and a legal vehicle is a serious buyer. An individual with 20k is not.

7. A public offering funds the next phase.

Courses, residencies, work-stays, markets, events. This is where you already have instinct — courses and events are the correct economic engine for years 1 to 5. Projects that skipped this (pure homesteading, no public face) almost always ran out of money.

What to steal from four communities that worked

Sieben Linden (Germany) — vision weekends

Before buying land, they ran monthly and quarterly gatherings with potential members for almost four years. Clear curriculum: vision, governance, economics, conflict. People self-selected out. By the time they bought land, the group was already a group. **Steal this:** don't skip the vision-weekend phase.

Tamera (Portugal) — scouts and Plan B weekends

Small teams visited potential locations together, lived in each one for weeks, and reported back. Land selection was a group process. They also ran public weekends that doubled as recruitment and vision-testing. **Steal this:** let the group choose the land; use your courses as the filter.

Findhorn (Scotland) — the permeable guest program

Anyone can come as a guest, work, attend workshops, and possibly stay. The boundary between visitor and member is permeable but structured. This solved their recruitment problem for sixty years. **Steal this:** design a clear pathway from *visitor* to *contributor* to *member*.

Crystal Waters (Australia) — the legal chassis

A body corporate owns the commons; individuals own their plots. Controversial in community circles, but one of the most stable long-term eco-projects in the world. **Steal this:** study their legal structure even if you end up rejecting the model. The form matters more than the feeling.

A practical first year

Months 1 to 3 — write and publish

Write the one-page manifesto. Share it in three places: your personal network, an international community like ic.org or GEN Europe, and one in-person event where aligned people already gather.

Months 3 to 6 — first weekend

Run a cheap, modest weekend. Ten to twenty people. Friend's land, rented finca, borrowed space. The goal isn't to start the community — it is to see who comes back.

Months 6 to 12 — returners and co-writing

Quarterly gatherings with the people who returned. Co-write the vision. Identify four to eight potential co-founders. Decide the legal form.

Months 12 to 18 — shared rental

A house or finca the core group lives in or uses intensively together. This is the real filter.

Months 18 to 24 — legal entity, land search, first course

Set up the *associação* or *cooperativa*. Pool money. Search land as a group. Run a public course from the rental base to test the economic engine before committing to a purchase.

Your 20,000 € is the seed for the rental phase and the legal setup. Not the land.

Questions to bring to our conversation

- What is the one sentence that describes your project — specifically enough that it would turn some people away?
- Where are you already in front of aligned people? If nowhere yet, that is step zero.
- Who are the three people you would invite to a first weekend in the next ninety days?
- What is the smallest public offering (a course, a weekend, a residency) you could run in the next six months from any space, even rented?
- Which of the four communities above feels closest to your instinct — and which feels furthest? (Both answers matter.)
- What are you afraid of losing by being specific?

— *Terra Alta Permaculture · Sintra*